But within, you thirsted for the blood of Muslims

You killed many brothers of mine
And now you say that I am murdering you?

I am extracting blood vengeance by law
With the blood of your throat I will wash you clean of blood.'[73]

It is certainly true that the Shah was a deeply flawed man and made many errors of judgement. He was rarely an impressive leader in war and his arrogance and hauteur alienated potential followers throughout his career; as William Fraser noted soon after he crossed the frontier into British India for the first time in 1816, he was indeed 'very Ultra-Royal in his wishes and expectations'.[74] This belief derived from Shuja's essentially Timurid view of his own kingship: as he wrote to Lord Bentinck in 1834, he believed himself to be 'under the special protection of God'.[75]

Yet, for all this, Shuja was a remarkable man: highly educated, intelligent, resolute and above all unbreakable. Throughout his life he was fated to suffer desperate and repeated reverses, often for reasons quite outside his own control, but he never gave up nor ever gave way to despair. 'Lose no hope when faced with hardships,' he wrote in his youth while on the run after the blinding and deposition of his brother. 'Black clouds soon give way to clear rain.'[76] This optimism remained a strength throughout his life. Observers constantly remarked on his 'grace and dignity', even in the most adverse circumstances.[77] The British called him ineffectual, and Burnes in particular mocked him as the man who lost the kingdom of his ancestors; but when the moment of crisis came at the outbreak of rebellion in November 1841, Shuja was the only figure in Kabul to offer an effective military response, and the only person who made any attempt to save Burnes, even though Burnes had always done his best to humiliate him.

Shuja was always unusual for his honourable loyalty to his allies and his faithfulness to his agreements, in a region not known for either. This was one reason he never forgave the Barakzais for breaking the arrangement made between his grandfather, Ahmad Shah Abdali, and Dost Mohammad's grandfather, Haji Jamal Khan, that the Sadozais would rule as King, with the Barakzais as their faithful servants. He saw himself as the true heir to a highly cultured Persian-speaking Safavid and Timurid civilisation, and as well as writing fine verse and prose himself was a generous patron to poets and scholars, as Mountstuart Elphinstone discovered to his surprise when he